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In memory of Nellie Y. McKay

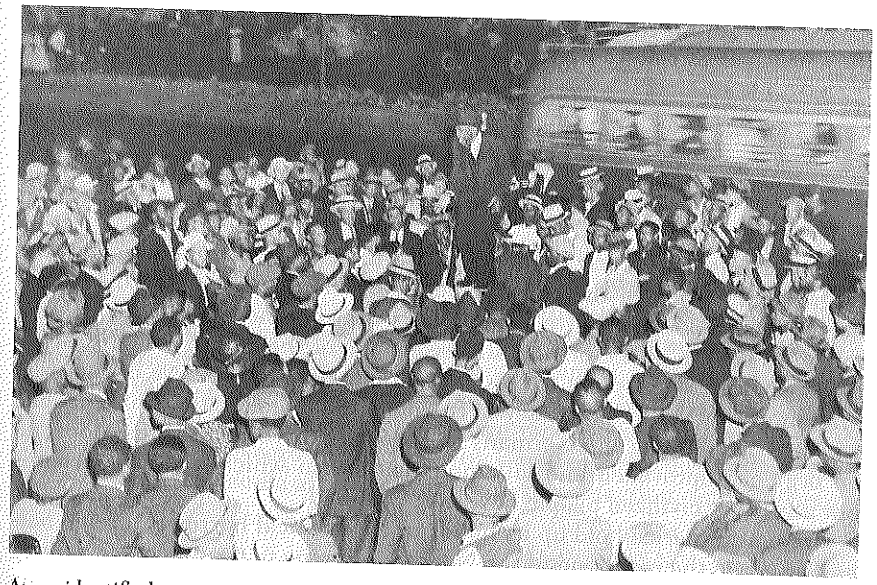
HUBERT HARRISON
1883–1927

In a 1923 article in the *Amsterdam News*, William Pickens wrote that "it is not possible that Socrates could have outdone Hubert Harrison in making the most commonplace subject interesting. Here is a plain black man who can speak more easily, effectively and interestingly, on a greater variety of subjects than any other man we have ever met, even in any of the great universities." The greatest soapbox orator in 1920s Harlem, Harrison was also a pioneering socialist organizer, a dazzling autodidact, an indefatigable editor and writer, and the "father of Negro radicalism," the major inspiration for the entire generation of black intellectuals who emerged after World War I, from Marcus Garvey to Claude McKay to A. Philip Randolph. As Randolph observed simply: "Hubert Harrison was far more advanced than we were."

Both of Harrison's working-class parents died when he was young; when he migrated to New York from his birthplace, St. Croix in the Danish West Indies, Harrison was forced to take a series of menial jobs (messenger, elevator operator, stock clerk, bellhop) to support himself while he attended high school at night. Nonetheless his prodigious intellectual gifts and fierce determination were immediately apparent. Omnivorous and free-thinking, with an extraordinary memory, he read constantly even outside of school, immersing himself in classic works in history, religion, philosophy, politics, and literature. Nor was he afraid to speak his mind in public. In late 1904, he sent a letter to the editor of the *New York Times* in which he criticized the paper for inflaming racial tensions with an editorial that referred to African Americans as "chicken-stealers." He was only a twenty-one-year-old fresh out of night school, but already his writing displayed a humor and devastating logic that would become characteristic: "I, as a Negro, can have no objection to a bit of news that reports a Jersey Negro, or many Jersey Negroes, as being dexterous stealers of chicken; but I strongly object to the sweeping opinion of any newspaper that we are a race of thieves—either of fowls or anything else." By the end of the decade he was publishing articles and reviews in the *Times* and elsewhere.

Unable to afford college, Harrison passed the exam for the postal service and settled in Harlem, but when in 1910 he published an article in the *New York Sun* criticizing Booker T. Washington, a politician beholden to Washington's infamous "Tuskegee Machine" connived to have Harrison fired. Harrison was subsequently hired to organize blacks by the Socialist Party of New York and founded a colored Socialist Club in Harlem. He also wrote a five-part series of articles on "The Negro and Socialism" for the *New York Call* in which he contended that "the crucial test of Socialism's sincerity" would be its commitment to the cause of African American advancement. By 1913, Harrison was a featured speaker at Socialist events such as the famous Paterson, New Jersey, silk strike (where he appeared with "Big Bill" Haywood and Elizabeth Gurley Flynn), but already he was beginning to rail in public against entrenched racism in the party. By May 1914 he was suspended for his public complaints; Harrison left the Socialist Party soon thereafter, and began teaching at the Ferrer Modern School and giving street lectures on various topics.

He began to promote the idea of "Race First," and in the summer of 1917 immediately after the brutal race riots in East St. Louis, Illinois (in which African Americans defended themselves against unprovoked attacks by white mobs), Harrison founded the Liberty League at a meeting at Harlem's Bethel African Methodist Episcopal Church, where one of the speakers was a relatively unknown Jamaican



An unidentified streetcorner orator, 1938. Harrison was the most famous of the dozens of street speakers who, lecturing from a stepladder or soapbox, drew large crowds in Harlem throughout the period, especially along Lenox and Seventh avenues.

in powerful language that they demonstrated a new "temper" among the black population: "If white men are to kill unoffending Negroes, Negroes must kill white men in defense of their lives and property."

Harrison published two books, *The Negro and the Nation* (1917) and *When Africa Awakes* (1920). Both were largely compilations of his brilliant newspaper writing. He was a master of the short form (the editorial, the review), and as Garvey's UNIA began to garner popular support, Harrison came to play a crucial role as the editor of the *Negro World*. He completely redesigned the paper and almost single-handedly launched a section of book and theater reviews. Very quickly, however, he became disillusioned with Garvey, incensed at his flamboyant megalomania, his compulsive self-aggrandizement and hunger for publicity, and his organizational sloppiness.

In 1923 Harrison took a position as a roving lecturer with the New York City Board of Education while continuing to publish on a remarkable breadth of topics. Two years later he founded another short-lived organization, the International Colored Unity League, and briefly edited a new journal called the *Voice of the Negro* before he died suddenly in 1927, reportedly from complications of appendicitis.

Harrison had a deep knowledge of literature and wrote a large body of book reviews. But he was not seduced by the Harlem Renaissance, which he considered a mirage, at best a "fool's paradise" of promotional hot air. In his most devastating dismissal, a 1927 article in the *Pittsburgh Courier*, he dubbed the renaissance the "Cabaret School," a product of whites convinced that the Negro "existed to furnish entertainment to others." These white "discoverers of 'The New Negro,'" Harrison wrote, sought whatever was "quaint, queer, odd, bizarre and different," and built a pseudo-movement on that premise: "The grotesques antics of bibulous balloons furnished the esthetic principles upon which a 'new' art for the New Negro was predicated." When younger black artists such as Zora Neale Hurston, Langston Hughes, and Helene Johnson pander to these stereotypes, Harrison wrote, they "often mistake the language of the gutter for the language of the common people and, since, 'spice' rhymes with 'nice,' they

School, still waiting for those who have gumption and courage enough to eschew the namby-pamby colored Brahmins and the seductions of the midnight maniacs from downtown."

The East St. Louis Horror

This nation is now at war to make the world "safe for democracy,"[1] but the Negro's contention in the court of public opinion is that until this nation itself is made safe for twelve million of its subjects the Negro, at least, will refuse to believe in the democratic assertions of the country. The East St. Louis pogrom[2] gives point to this contention. Here, on the eve of the celebration of the Nation's birthday of freedom and equality, the white people, who are denouncing the Germans as Huns and barbarians, break loose in an orgy of unprovoked and villainous barbarism which neither Germans nor any other civilized people have ever equalled.

How can America hold up its hands in hypocritical horror at foreign barbarism while the red blood of the Negro is clinging to those hands? So long as the President and Congress of the United States remain dumb in the presence of barbarities in their own land which would tip their tongues with righteous indignation if they had been done in Belgium, Ireland, or Galicia?

And what are the Negroes to do? Are they expected to re-echo with enthusiasm the patriotic protestations of the boot-licking leaders whose pockets and positions testify to the power of the white man's gold? Let there be no mistake. Whatever the Negroes may be compelled by law to do and say, the resentment in their hearts will not down. Unbeknown to the white people of this land a temper is being developed among Negroes with which the American people will have to reckon.

At the present moment it takes this form: If white men are to kill unoffending Negroes, Negroes must kill white men in defense of their lives and property. This is the lesson of the East St. Louis massacre.

The press reports declare that "the troops who were on duty during the most serious disturbances were ordered not to shoot." The civil and military authorities are evidently winking at the work of the mobs—horrible as that was—and the Negroes of the city need not look to them for protection. They must protect themselves. And even the United States Supreme Court concedes them this right.

There is, in addition, a method of retaliation which we urge upon them. It is one which will hit those white men who have the power to prevent lawlessness just where they will feel it most, in the place where they keep their consciences—the pocket-book. Let every Negro in East St. Louis and the other cities where race rioting occurs draw his money from the savings-bank and either bank it in the other cities or in the postal savings bank. The only part of the news reports with which we are well pleased is that which states that the property loss is already estimated at a million and a half dollars.

Another reassuring feature is the one suppressed in most of the news despatches. We refer to the evidences that the East St. Louis Negroes organized themselves during the riots and fought back under some kind of leadership. We Negroes will never know, perhaps, how many whites were killed by our enraged brothers in East St. Louis. It isn't the news-policy of the white newspapers (whether friendly or unfriendly) to spread such news broadcast. It might teach Negroes too much. But we will hope for the best.

The occurrence should serve to enlarge rapidly the membership of the Liberty League of Negro-Americans which was organized to take practical steps to help our people all over the land in the protection of their lives and liberties.

1917

1. On April 2, 1917, President Woodrow Wilson gave an address to a joint session of Congress requesting a Declaration of War against Germany in order that the world "be made safe for democracy."

2. Race riots erupted in East St. Louis on July 2, 1917, when whites, anxious over jobs and angry at the perceived competition from thousands of blacks who had recently migrated there from the South, attacked black neighborhoods, killing between 40 and 200 people and inflicting major property damage. Armed blacks defended themselves with violence, and at least 9 whites were killed. The events in East St. Louis were the first and bloodiest in a series of racial clashes across the country in cities including Houston, Texas (1917), Knoxville, Tennessee (1919), Washington, D.C. (1919), Chicago, Illinois (1919), Omaha, Nebraska (1919), and Longview, Texas (1919).

Two Negro Radicalisms

Twenty years ago all Negroes known to the white publicists of America could be classed as conservatives on all the great questions on which thinkers differ. In matters of industry, commerce, politics, religion, they could be trusted to take the backward view. Only on the question of the Negro's "rights" could a small handful be found bold enough to be tagged as "radicals"—and they were howled down by both the white and colored adherents of the conservative point of view. Today Negroes differ on all those great questions on which white thinkers differ, and there are Negro radicals of every imaginable stripe—agnostics, atheists, I.W.W.'s, Socialists, Single Taxers,[1] and even Bolshevists.

In the good old days white people derived their knowledge of what Negroes were doing from those Negroes who were nearest to them, generally their own selected exponents of Negro activity or of their white point of view. A classic illustration of this kind of knowledge was afforded by the Republican Party; but the Episcopal Church, the Urban League, or the U.S. Government would serve as well. To-day the white world is vaguely, but disquietingly, aware that Negroes are awake, different and perplexingly uncertain. Yet the white world by which they are surrounded retains its traditional method of interpreting the mass by the Negro nearest to themselves in affiliation or contact. The Socialist party thinks that the "unrest" now apparent in the Negro masses is due to the propaganda which its adherents support, and believes that it will function largely along the lines of socialist political thought. The great dailies, concerned mainly with their

1. Proponents of the movement associated with the writings of the economist Henry George (1839–1897), who advocated the idea of a single tax on the value of land. "I.W.W's": The Industrial Workers of the World, known as the "Wobblies," an international union founded in 1905.

chosen task of being the mental bellwethers of the mob, scream "Bolshevist propaganda" and flatter themselves that they have found the true cause; while the government's unreliable agents envisage it as "disloyalty." The truth, as usual, is to be found in the depths: but they are all prevented from going by mental laziness and that traditional off-handed, easy contempt with which white men in America, from scholars like Lester Ward to scavengers like Stevenson,[2] deign to consider the colored population of 12 millions.

In the first place the cause of the "radicalism" among American Negroes is international. But it is necessary to cause clear distinctions at the outset. The function of the Christian church is international. So is art, war, the family, rum and exploitation of labor. But none of these is entitled to extend the mantle of its own peculiar "internationalism" to cover the present case of the Negro discontent—although this has been attempted. The international Fact to which Negroes in America are now reacting is not the exploitation of laborers by capitalists; but the social, political and economic subjection of colored peoples by white. It is not the Class Line, but the Color line, which is the incorrect but accepted expression for the Dead Line of racial inferiority. This fact is a fact of Negro consciousness as well as a fact of externals. The international Color Line is the practice and theory of that doctrine which holds that the best stocks of Africa, China, Egypt and the West Indies are inferior to the worst stocks of Belgium, England, and Italy, and must hold their lives, lands and liberties upon such terms and conditions as the white races may choose to grant them.

On the part of the whites, the motive was originally economic; but it is no longer purely so. All the available facts go to prove that, whether in the United States or in Africa or China, the economic subjection is without exception keener and more brutal when the exploited are black, brown and yellow, than when they are white. And the fact that black, brown, and yellow also exploit each other brutally whenever Capitalism has created the economic classes of plutocrat and proletarian should suffice to put purely economic subjection out of court as the prime cause of racial unrest. For the similarity of suffering has produced in all lands where whites rule colored races a certain similarity of sentiment, viz: a racial revulsion of racial feeling. The peoples of those lands begin to feel and realize that they are so subjected because they are members of races condemned as "inferior" by their Caucasian overlords. The fact presented to their minds is one of race, and in terms of race do they react to it. Put the case to any Negro by way of test and the answer will make this clear.

The great World War, by virtue of its great advertising campaign for democracy and the promises which were held out to subject peoples, fertilized the Race Consciousness of the Negro people into the stage of conflict with the dominant white idea of the Color Line. They took democracy at its face value—which is—Equality. So did the Hindus, Egyptians, and West Indians. This is what the hypocritical advertisers of democracy had not bargained for. The American Negroes, like the other darker peoples, are presenting their checques and trying to "cash in," and delays in that process, however unavoidable to the paying tellers, are bound to beget a

plentiful lack of belief in either their intention or in their ability to pay. Hence the run on Democracy's bank—"the Negro unrest" of the newspaper paragraphers.

This Race Consciousness takes many forms, some negative, others positive. On the one hand we balk at Jim Crow, object to educational starvation, refuse to accept good-will for good deeds, and scornfully reject our conservative leaders. On the other hand, we are seeking racial independence in business and reaching out into new fields of endeavor. One of the most taking enterprises at present is the Black Star Line, a steamship enterprise being floated by Mr. Marcus Garvey of New York. Garvey's project (whatever may be its ultimate fate) has attracted tens of thousands of Negroes. Where Negro "radicals" of the type known to white radicals can scarce get a handful of people, Garvey fills the largest halls and the Negro people rain money on him. This is not to be explained by the argument of "superior brains," for this man's education and intelligence are markedly inferior to those of the brilliant "radicals" whose "internationalism" is drawn from other than racial sources. But this man holds up to the Negro masses those things which bloom in their hearts—racialism, race-consciousness, racial solidarity—things taught first in 1917 by *THE VOICE* and The Liberty League. That is the secret of his success so far.

All over this land and in the West Indies Negroes are responding to the call of battle against the white man's Color Line. And, so long as this remains, the international dogma of the white race, so long will the new Negro war against it. This is the very Ethiopianism which England has been combatting from Cairo to the Cape.

Undoubtedly some of these newly-awakened Negroes will take to Socialism and Bolshevism. But here again the reason is racial. Since they suffer racially from the world as at present organized by the white race, some of their ablest hold that it is "good play" to encourage and give aid to every subversive movement within that white world which makes for its destruction "as it is." For by its subversion they have much to gain and nothing to lose. But they build on their own foundations. Parallel with the dogma of Class-Consciousness they run the dogma of Race-Consciousness. And they dig deeper. For the roots of Class-consciousness inhere in a temporary economic order; whereas the roots of Race-consciousness must of necessity survive any and all changes in the economic order. Accepting biology as a fact, their view is the more fundamental. At any rate, it is that view with which the white world will have to deal.

1919